

Difficult Conversations Business English Lesson · Speaking & Vocabulary · B2 Level

About This Resource: This lesson was designed for a B2 level business English speaking student to build confidence and fluency in navigating workplace conversations that require tact, diplomacy, and precise language. The focus is functional language to give the student concrete phrases they can use immediately in real professional situations.

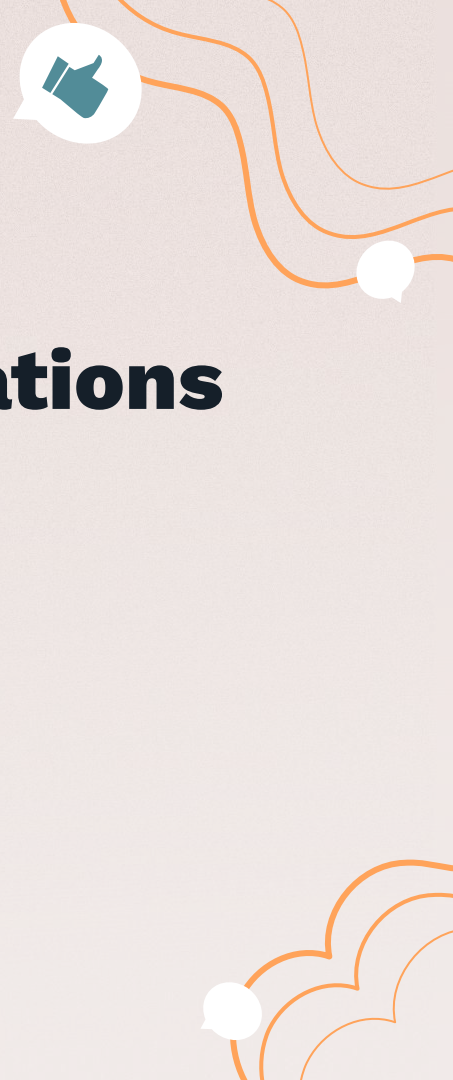
Lesson structure: The lesson follows a communicate, input, practice sequence. It opens with warm-up activities that activate vocabulary and lower affective barriers before introducing any target language.

Task-based design: Role-play situations move from lower-stakes scenarios to higher-stakes ones, building student confidence progressively. The homework extends the lesson into writing, asking students to apply the same indirect language in polished professional emails.

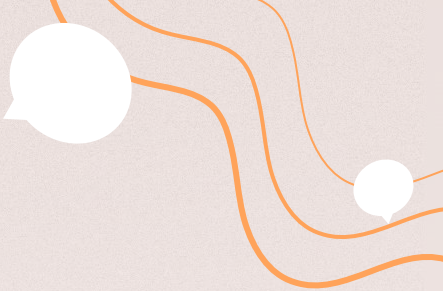
Audience considerations: B2 learners have enough fluency to engage in extended conversation but often lack the register awareness needed to navigate sensitive professional interactions in English. This lesson directly targets that gap



Difficult Conversations



Agenda



01 Warm up

02 Softening
Phrases

03 Difficult
Conversations

04 Homework



Warm up - Scattergories!

1. reason to cancel a meeting _____
2. reason to have a meeting _____
3. excuse for being late for work _____
4. positive adjective for a manager _____
5. negative adjective for a manager _____
6. well-known person in your field (first or last name) _____
7. something people keep on their desks _____
8. department in a company _____

Warm up - Scattergories!

1. reason to quit your job _____
2. weekend activity _____
3. word related to banking/finance _____
4. perk/benefit _____
5. something that gets you in trouble with HR _____
6. reason to ignore a phone call _____
7. something people lie about at work _____
8. item in this room _____



“Can I have Friday off?”

Is this an appropriate way to ask your boss for the day off?



Think

- Have you ever had a difficult conversation in English?
- What was the situation?
- What are some of the most difficult topics for you?
How do you manage these conversations in English?



Which of the conversations would you consider difficult? Why?

**Quitting your
job**

**Dealing with a
very upset
customer**

**Confronting a
coworker
about their
behavior**

**Firing
someone**

**Admitting
failure**

**Negotiating
terms of a
contract**

Would it be easier for you to have these conversations in your first language rather than in English?

**Quitting your
job**

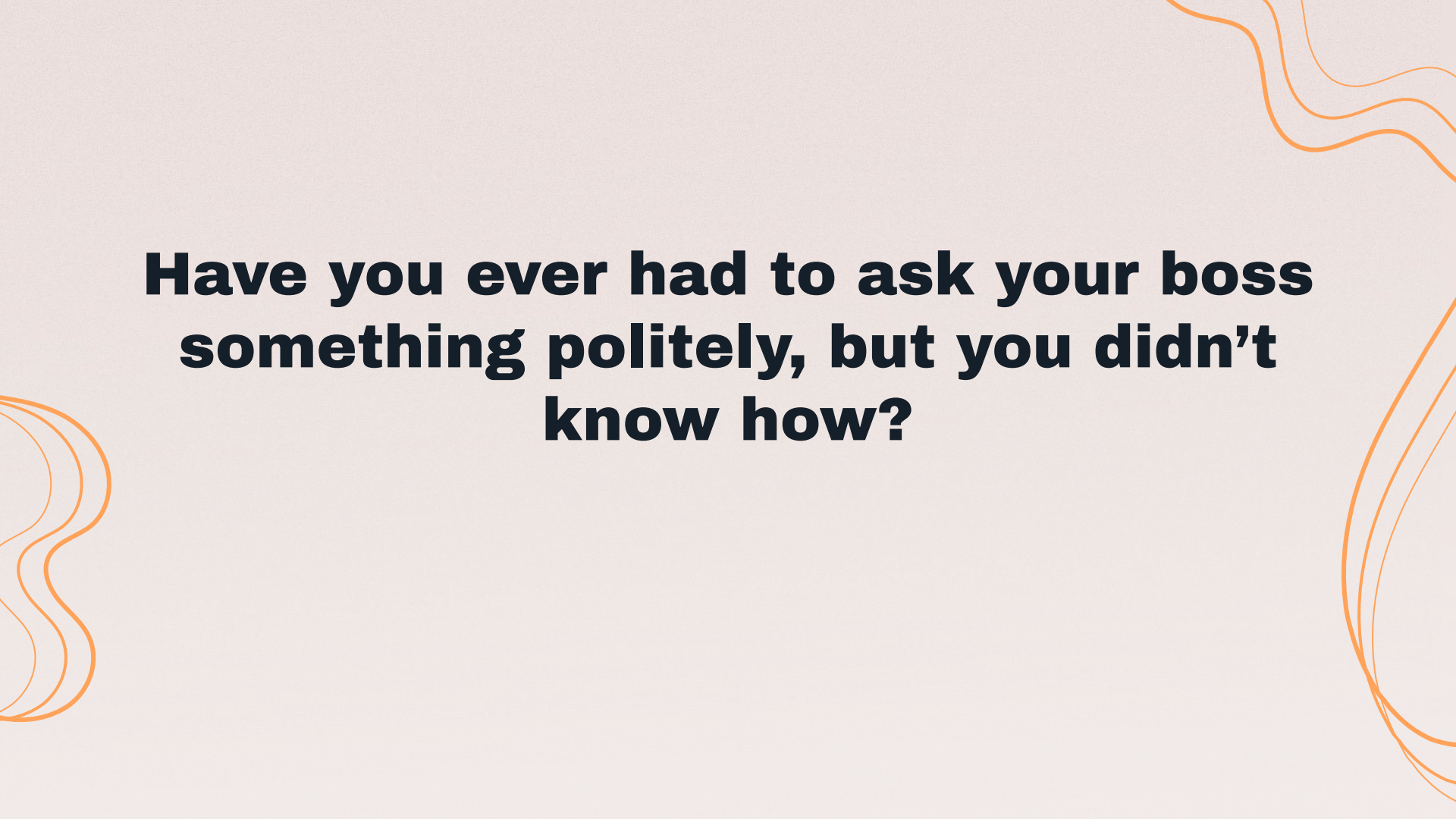
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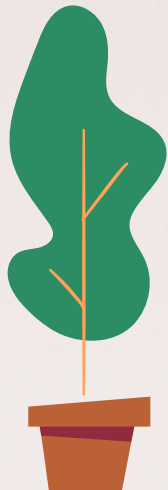
The image features a light beige background with decorative orange wavy lines in the top right and bottom left corners. The text is centered and reads:

**Have you ever had to ask your boss
something politely, but you didn't
know how?**



Could vs. can

Using “could” instead of “can” does make a request more polite but **there are phrases we use to be less direct and more polite when we make requests.**





We mostly use these phrases in the following situations:

- 
1. When the person to whom we are making the request does not have an obligation to say yes.
 2. When we are making a big request.
 3. When we are making a request to someone who is at a higher level within the company.
- 

Softening Phrases

Polite, indirect ways of asking for something.

I was hoping I could....

I was hoping you could work this Saturday.

I was hoping I could take Friday off.

I was wondering if I could....

I was wondering if you could cover my shift next Tuesday.

I was wondering if I could take an extended lunch break to run some errands.

Do you think I might be able to....

Do you think you might be able to help me out with these reports?

Do you think I might be able to leave a few minutes early so I can pick up my child from school?

The situation:

Someone from outside the company visited your office and gave a presentation. You thought it was a great presentation and you would like a copy of the Power Point slides. How would you ask the presenter for the document?



The situation:

You work in sales. A customer has just called you and complained about always receiving his shipments late. He's very upset and wants you to expedite his current order. The computer system shows that your customer's order won't ship until tomorrow, so you decide to call the warehouse manager and ask if she can make sure the order ships by the end of the day. How would you ask her for this favor?



The situation:

Something unexpected happened this morning and you are late for work. You realize that you do not have your supervisor's phone number. You decide to call a coworker and ask her to tell the boss that you will be late. How would you ask your coworker to do this for you?



The situation:

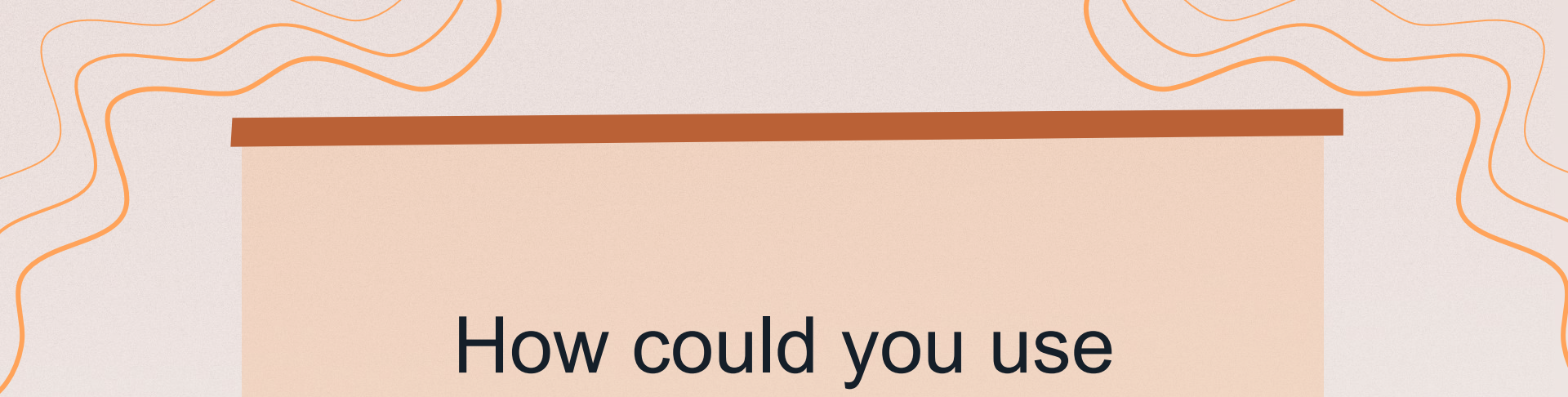
You are looking for a new job and are sending applications to prospective employers. You would like to supplement your applications with letters of recommendation from previous employers. You decide to call Carol, your former supervisor, and ask her to write you a letter of recommendation. What would you say to Carol?



“Can I have Friday off?”

What is a better way to ask your boss for a day off?





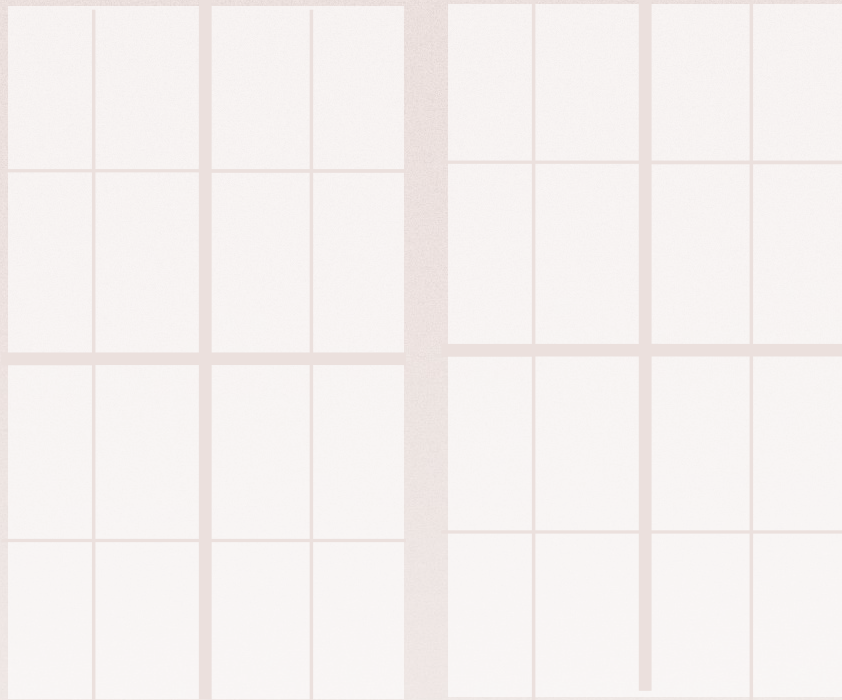
How could you use
softening phrases in
your work life?



Complete each pair of sentences with a word in the box in the correct form.

defuse hijack stabilize untangle validate wrench

- a) You need to your emotions from the subject matter. I tried to the cables on the floor.
- b) I got by my emotions and overreacted to her words. The aircraft has been We've alerted the authorities.
- c) She didn't feel by her family because they overlooked her efforts. The theory has been by experimental results.
- d) I'm having trouble my thoughts after the call. Water also provides the means of body temperature.
- e) She cracked a joke to tension. The road was closed while the police tried to the bomb.
- f) It was a gut-..... experience. They tried to the bag from him but he managed to keep it.

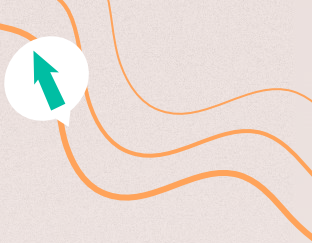


Difficult conversations Day 2



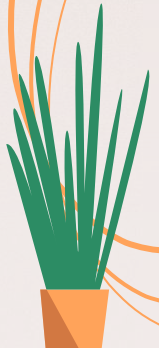
**Have you ever had an
uncomfortable conversation
with your boss or coworker?**

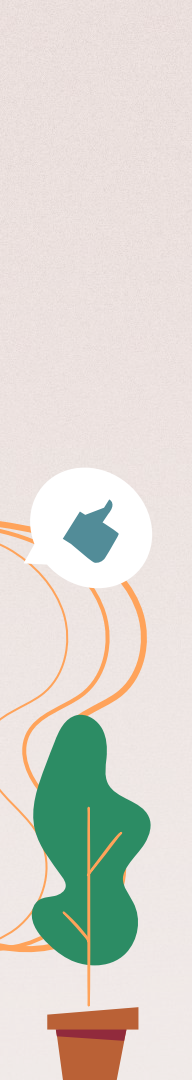




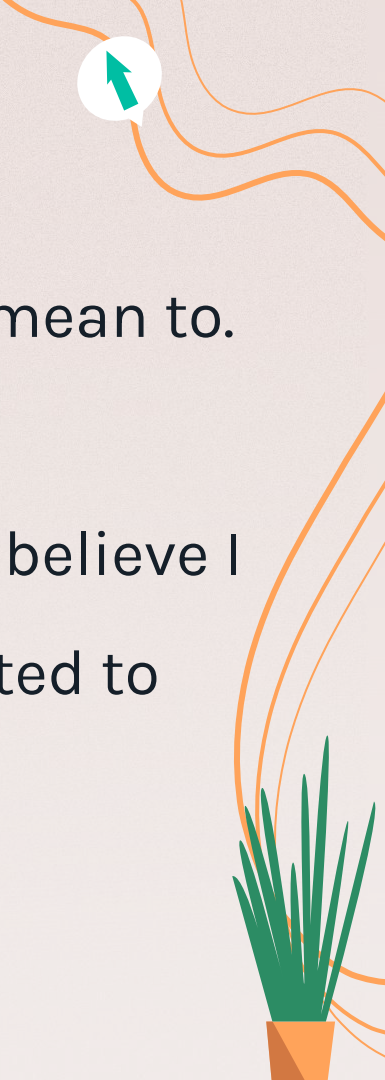
Awkward or inappropriate topics

- I'm uncomfortable talking about this.
- Could we talk about something else?
- This is making me uncomfortable, could we change the subject?
- I don't think this is the time to discuss this.





Someone was offended

- I think I may have offended you. I didn't mean to.
 - I'm sorry, I didn't mean to offend you.
 - That isn't what I meant to express, and I believe I may have hurt your feelings. What I wanted to say was....
 - There seems to be a misunderstanding.
- 

A mistake was made

- I'm terribly sorry about any inconvenience I may have caused.
- Please accept my apologies.
- I'm very sorry about that.





When it isn't a good time

- Let's talk later.
- Let's continue this conversation tomorrow.
- I'm sorry, I've gotta run. Let's talk later.
- Why don't we discuss this tomorrow at lunch?

Disagreeing

- I'm sorry, I simply don't agree with you on that.
- I understand, but I disagree.
- I have some reservations about that.



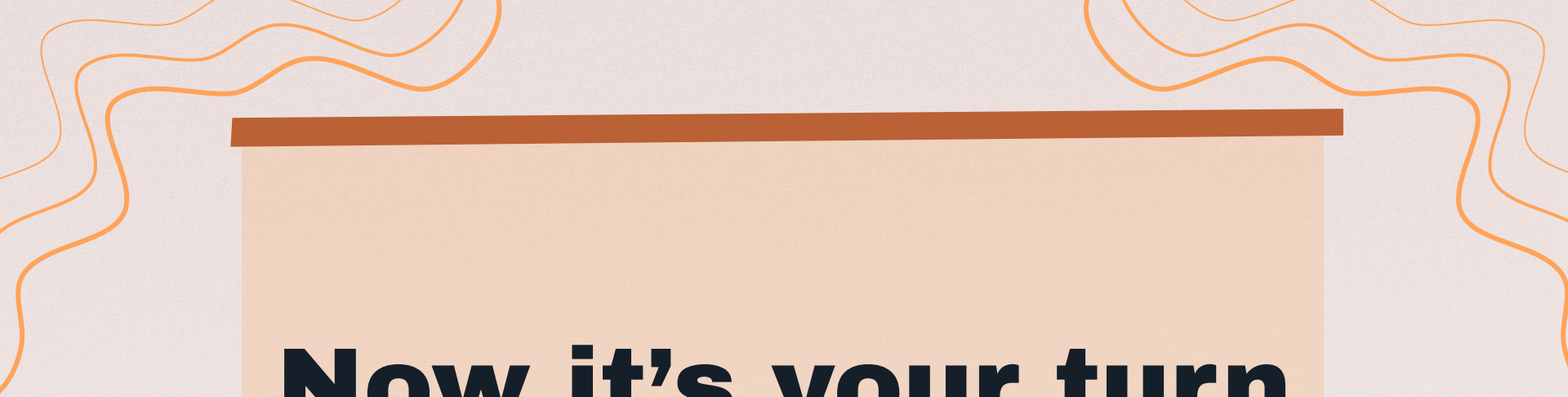
Asking someone to avoid something

- Would you mind not discussing that at the meeting?
- Could you please avoid mentioning that problem?



Avoiding commitment

- You'd better ask someone else to do that. I'm not sure I'll be able to.
- I really can't make any promises. I have so much on my hands already.
- I don't think I can handle that right now. Why don't you ask someone else?



Now it's your turn



Situation 1

Situation: Coworker 1 suspects that Coworker 2 has been stealing his lunch from the fridge every now and then. The two must have a conversation to resolve this issue.

Situation 2

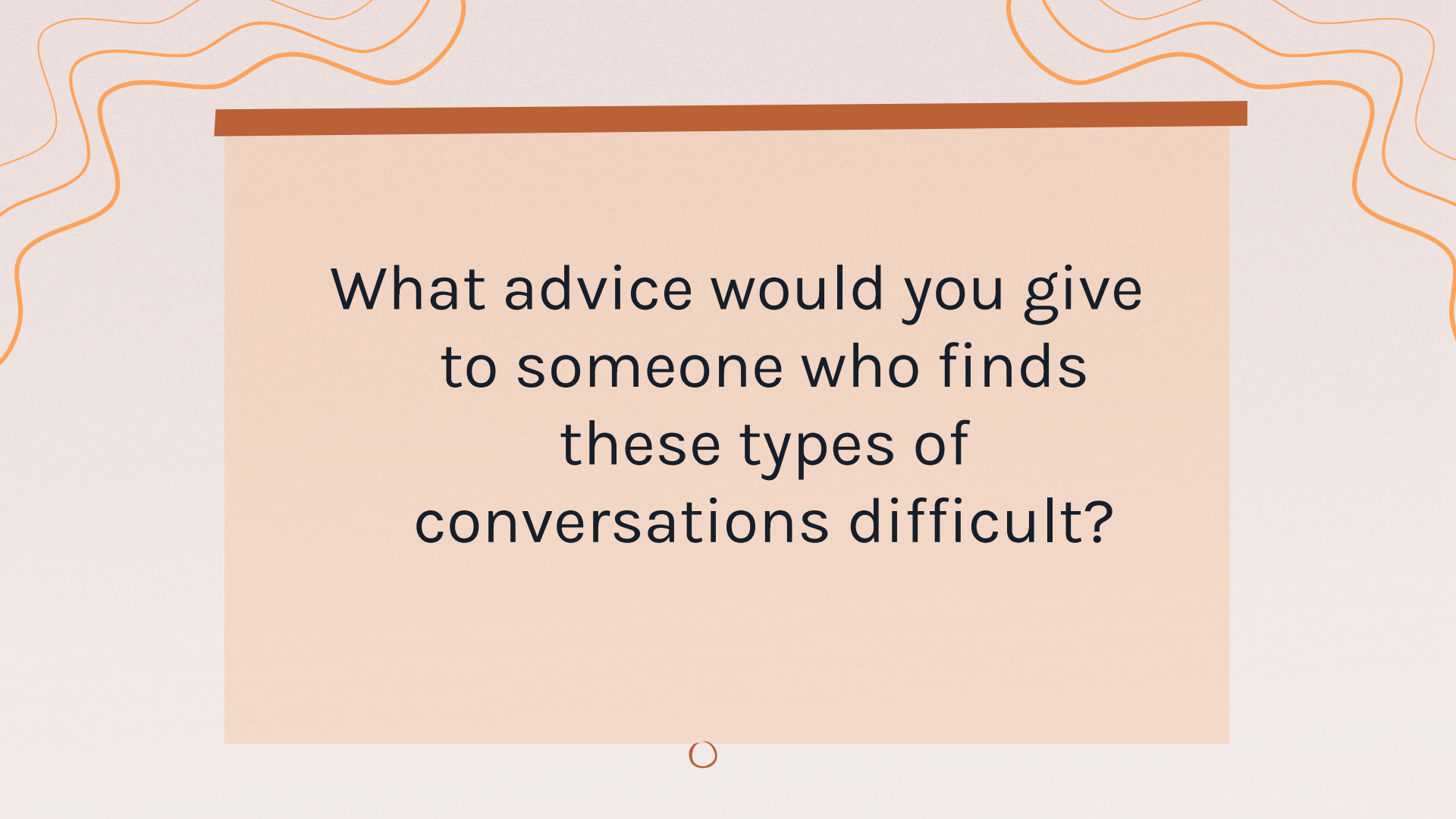
Situation: Coworker 1 feels offended because Coworker 2 laughed at a joke that was at the expense of a specific group of people. Coworker 1 must express his feelings and Coworker 2 should respond.

Situation 3

Situation: The boss must confront the team members about a decrease in productivity. The team member should defend their work.

Situation 4

Situation: The boss is creating a new area to work on a specific project and must ask the team member to be the leader of this area. However, the team member already has a lot of work on his plate and this new area would require a significant increase in workload.



What advice would you give
to someone who finds
these types of
conversations difficult?



Homework

Write emails for the situations below. Be polite and indirect.

1. You have some suggestions about how to get more business. You want to meet with one of the managers and talk about this business opportunity. Write a polite email requesting a 30-minute meeting.
2. You have some personal issues you need to take care of on Tuesday morning. You'd like to take Tuesday morning off and make up the time later in the week. Write a polite email to your supervisor explaining the situation. Ask for permission to take the time off and make it up later in the week.
3. *Your own situation*: Are there any situations you regularly deal with that require polite, indirect emails? Think of a situation and write a polite email.

Start at 1:44



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